

The Royal Society in Fleet Street

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The Royal Society, the oldest scientific academy in the world, was founded in 1660 at Gresham College in London. The Society met there for about 50 years. By 1710, Sir Isaac Newton, the Society's President, wanted a new home away from his late rival Robert Hooke.

The Society bought a house in Crane Court, off Fleet Street, for £1,450, with a small adjoining house to rent. The first meeting there was on 8 November 1710. Some Fellows complained the house was dark, small, and had a long courtyard that left visitors wet in the rain.

Sir Christopher Wren, a famous architect, helped make the building suitable. He designed an extension for the Society's museum, or Repository, which held ordinary items like seashells and seeds, as well as extraordinary objects like a crocodile skeleton and a dodo leg. The extension cost £400 and may have been Wren's last building design.

In 1778, Sir Joseph Banks became President and stayed for nearly 42 years. He accepted a government offer to move the Society to Somerset House. The final meeting at Crane Court was on 23 November 1780. After that, the property was sold, and the Royal Society continued its work in science from its new home, ending its long connection with Fleet Street.



*A meeting of the Royal Society
in Crane Court*